

ON AFZAL'S MERCY PETITION



"THE EXISTING LAWS ARE ENOUGH TO CONTROL TERROR ACTS AND TO PROTECT HUMAN RIGHTS."

to fight a battle against terrorist. We have to train them for that. Then you need to give them the equipment they require. In other countries, it is the defence forces that are fighting against terrorism.

Q. Are the existing laws enough to handle terrorism?

A. The existing provisions are enough to help the police to discharge their duties.

Q. Some states have asked for implementation of certain special laws. Why don't you accede to their request?

A. The existing laws are enough to control terrorist activities and to protect human rights. In a country like ours, there are two things that we have to do: one is to see that the terrorist activities or the criminal activities are controlled and the other thing is to see that the innocent people are not put into difficulty and their human rights are protected. We should strike a balance between the two.

Q. In the name of human rights, POTA was withdrawn. But TADA was also misused by previous governments.

A. The same people who opposed TADA and demanded its withdrawal brought in POTA. So why then did they oppose TADA in the first place?

Q. Let me come to Afzal Guru now. The Supreme Court has upheld his death penalty, but his mercy petition is pending with you.

A. It is not pending with me. It is pending with the Delhi Government. I am not the boss of the elected Government of Delhi. We are waiting for their reply.

Q. Why are they taking their own time? They must be having some reason.

A. Yes.

Q. What about the Naxalite threat?

A. Economic issues are involved and they cannot be solved by using the gun. If there are economic issues, then you have to find economic solutions. If there are social issues, then social solutions. So the social solutions, economic solutions, police solutions, policy solutions have to go together to handle it. And we cannot ask the state governments to do it.

Q. But Naxalites and terrorists are joining hands.

A. Terrorism is a philosophy pro-

pounded by people who feel democracy is no good, the economic and social systems are unfair and have to be changed not by the ballot, but with the bullet.

Q. There is an impression that there is no proper coordination between the Centre and state intelligence agencies.

A. You have to understand that we have RAW for external intelligence, IB for domestic and the CID and the special branches in the states. If state intelligence is weak, there is little we can do except to ask them to improve it. Of course, we are giving them funds to modernise.

Q. Is there a need for one centralised agency for intelligence purposes?

A. Yes, we have proposed that but the states are not agreeing. Even if I have to send two policemen to a state, I can't do it without their permission. It will definitely help the states act in better coordination.

Q. The arrests in Ahmedabad blasts have been a major breakthrough.

A. I am not taking credit for this; they have done it. Police from several states acted jointly to arrest the suspects.

Q. But don't you think the Ahmedabad model is the way ahead?

A. I have not criticised the model. But you are trying to get some kudos for them. If you'll be happy, I'll give you. I told you that in Malegaon, they have done it, in Mumbai they have done it, in Varanasi they have done it. If you want I can give you a list of cases where they have done it. And chargesheets have been filed and the people, who have been arrested, are not arrested in their states, somebody has been arrested on the borders of Bangladesh and Nepal. They have done well. We are happy that they have succeeded.

Q. What is the way forward to tackle terrorism?

A. The way forward is doing economic justice, being vigilant all the time so that the terrorists do not take advantage, and then preparing our forces to cope with them using modern weapons with modern technology.

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